

The Bigger Game

The launch of the Xbox is a continuation of Microsoft's acceleration into greener pastures. The booming popularity of video game consoles will help Microsoft get a firmer foothold in the entertainment arena, which it has previously entered via its Interactive TV, gaming software and online gaming services. The video game consoles will help Microsoft reach out to the masses right where they play—in their homes. No wonder Microsoft is spending half a billion dollars on a product that will not be even remotely profitable before 2004.

as a hybrid of first person shooters and third person shooters on the PC. According to Microsoft, the new games with Xbox will see massive realms, new realities, dynamic worlds and detailed characters.

More than a console at heart

The Xbox is not just a gaming console, but also a home entertainment system that can play movies and music. You can copy audio CDs to the hard drive and use the console to play your music in resounding 5.1 Dolby surround sound.

In addition to working on standard televisions, the Xbox will work with newer HDTV models as well, both in the normal and widescreen views. The full capabilities of the Xbox will truly be exploited only at 16:9 viewing resolutions on HDTV screens. Couple that with Dolby 5.1 surround and 256 sound channels and you have the richest gaming experiences possible. Adding the optional DVD movie playback kit will let you play DVDs like the Sony PlayStation 2. (See table, 'The X vs the Ex').

Powerplay—The X vs the Ex: A Hardware and Feature Comparison

	Microsoft Xbox	Sony PlayStation 2	Nintendo GameCube
Processor	Pentium III 733 MHz	294.912 MHz	405 MHz PowerPC
Graphics processor	250 MHz custom GeForce 3 chip	147.156 MHz	202.5 MHz custom chip 'Flipper'
Memory	64 MB	32 MB	43 MB
Storage	2.5x DVD, 8GB HDD, 8 MB memory card	4x DVD, 8 MB memory card	Proprietary 1.5 GB disk, 0.5 MB Digiraid
I/O ports	Controller x1, Ethernet (10/100)	Controller x2, USB, 1394, PCMCIA	Controller x1, serial port x2, parallel port
3D audio support in hardware	64 3D channels	No	No
Net connectivity	Future service	Future upgrade	Optional
DVD movie playback	Accessory required	Yes	No
HDTV movie support	Plays HD TV games and movies	Plays HD TV movies	No
Price	\$299	\$299	\$199
Game availability	Several AAA PC titles	A strong line-up of games	Popular titles with the under-17 audience

The Xbox' Ethernet connection, which is designed for cable and DSL modem hookups, will allow console gamers to experience the thrill of multiplayer gaming which has so far remained the preserve of PC gamers. You will also have the ability to download new characters and missions for the games you own. Its Ethernet adapter sets it up as the backbone for any future multiplayer services that might arise. Although there are no online gaming services yet, people are already jumping in and setting up vicious *Halo* deathmatches using GameSpy Tunnel, a service that allows you to play Xbox games over the Internet with the help of a PC.

Deathmatch

Console gaming, a Japanese domain right from its inception, is now being challenged on its own turf by the Xbox. The PlayStation2 from Sony already has a

year's lead in the US and an 18-month lead in Japan. Although earlier it had a none-too-great opening line-up of games, currently it has some trailblazing titles—*Metal Gear Solid II*, *Gran Turismo III* and *Devil May Cry*. *Final Fantasy* from Square has often turned out to be the reason for many gamers to buy the Sony PlayStation.

Microsoft has a tough road ahead. Its opponents in the gaming field, Sony and Nintendo, have been in this industry for over a decade now and have strong alliances with developers and partners, while Microsoft has no prior experience in this arena. It now has to prove itself on various unfamiliar fronts.

Microsoft has the money, time and skills to make things happen. With the Xbox, it has marked itself an entrant to the console industry, and by the time the Xbox 2 is released, it would have a significantly higher leverage in the console market.

The PC Connection

Console gamers have traditionally been a breed apart from PC gamers. However, the Xbox bridges the gap between the two. In addition to Windows 2000 and DirectX API, Microsoft has used components from some of the leading manufacturers. The Intel motherboard uses an Intel Pentium III processor, 64 MB of RAM and an nVidia graphics card. Several additional signs of the PC's architecture can be seen such as the Dolby Digital compatible soundcard, a conventional PC hard drive, the DVD-ROM

drive and an Ethernet card that will allow you to connect several computers together on a network.

Traditional PC favourites such as *Giants: Citizen Kabuto*, *Max Payne*, *Black and White*, and *NBA Live 2002* will soon be available on the Xbox. In addition to this will be all new titles such as *Unreal Championship*, which will be the next generation of the popular *Unreal Tournament* series. Other Xbox titles will include *WWF Raw is War* and *Star Wars: Obi-Wan Back*.

Keeping the promise

About \$55 to \$60 million next-generation consoles are expected to sell over the next half-decade.

However, the Indian subcontinent is not on the roadmap of any of these console manufacturers. Xbox will hit Korea and South Africa by November 2002. The Xbox will not be released in China because of the severe piracy situation there, which makes it a bad proposition.

If the same analogy applies to India, then perhaps we may see the Xbox only in the grey market. ■

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